Rightsizing Engagement Recap: What We Heard
October 13 - 19, 2026

Executive Summary

This memo is a weekly summary created by the Data & Accountability team to share public feedback on the proposed Rightsizing Scenarios. It covers community input gathered betwee**n October 13 and October 19, 2026.** These weekly reports exist to make the decision-making process open and transparent.

During the week of October 13–19, Portland Public Schools hosted two public engagement sessions:

- The Village Table | October 14
- Community Voice: Special Education Families | October 15
- Board of Education Community Connection | October 17
- School Impact: Northeast Region | Oct 17
- Latino/a/e Community Conversation | October 19

This summary is based on 1,501 survey responses and participation across five community events. 95% of participants represent school communities directly affected by potential closures, boundary shifts, or program changes. Across all regions, families identified transportation, safe walking routes, and keeping student peer cohorts together as essential supports during any transition. Community members raised equity concerns, urging the district to protect Special Education and Dual Language Immersion programs while addressing physical facility inequalities between buildings. Regionally, priorities varied from middle school feeder patterns in the Southeast and aging facilities in the West to preserving Title I services and cultural history in the North and Northeast.

In this What We Heard memo, we present survey responses disaggregated by impact region, as well as summaries of what we heard at community engagement events across the district.

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Introduction

Every Monday, from when the rightsizing plans were released on October 5th until Superintendent Armstrong gives her recommendation to the board, the Data and Accountability team will gather and summarize public feedback. The purpose of these reports is to be open and clear. We want to share what community members have told us and explain how we will use that information. This memo shares what we have heard from our community between October 13 - 19, 2026.

Scenario Feedback Survey Findings to Date

As of October 19th, we have received 1,501 responses from parents/guardians, PPS staff, students, and community members representing all of our school communities! About 95% of respondents represented school communities affected by the rightsizing scenario proposals in some way, including school closure, school consolidation, program changes, or boundary changes. See Tables 1-3 for a breakdown of respondent demographics, and see Appendix A for counts of responses by school to date.

Table 1:
Percentage of Respondents Representing Community Roles

Community Group	% Of Respondents
Parent/Guardian	74%
Student	3%
Staff/Educator	7%
Community Member	16%

Table 2:
Percentage of Respondents with Students Receiving Services

Services Received	% Of Respondents
Special Education	20%
Multilingual Learner Services	1%
Dual Language Immersion	13%
Talented and Gifted	21%
None of the above/Prefer not to say	45%

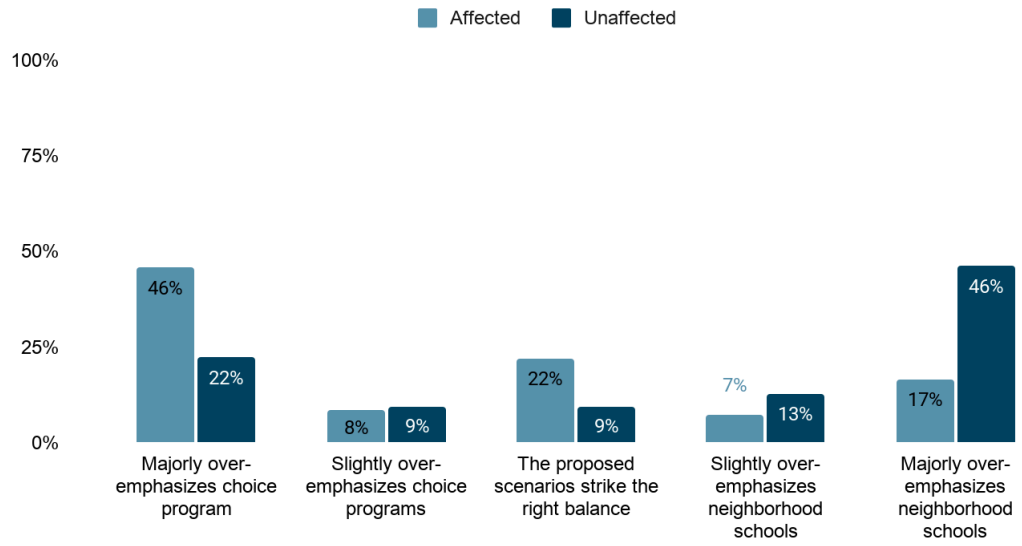
Table 3:
Percentage of Respondents by Race/Ethnicity

Race/Ethnicity of Respondents	% Of Respondents
Asian	4%
Black/African American	3%
Latino/a/e	6%
Native American	1%
NHPI	<1%
White	65%
Multi-Racial	7%
Prefer Not to Say	14%

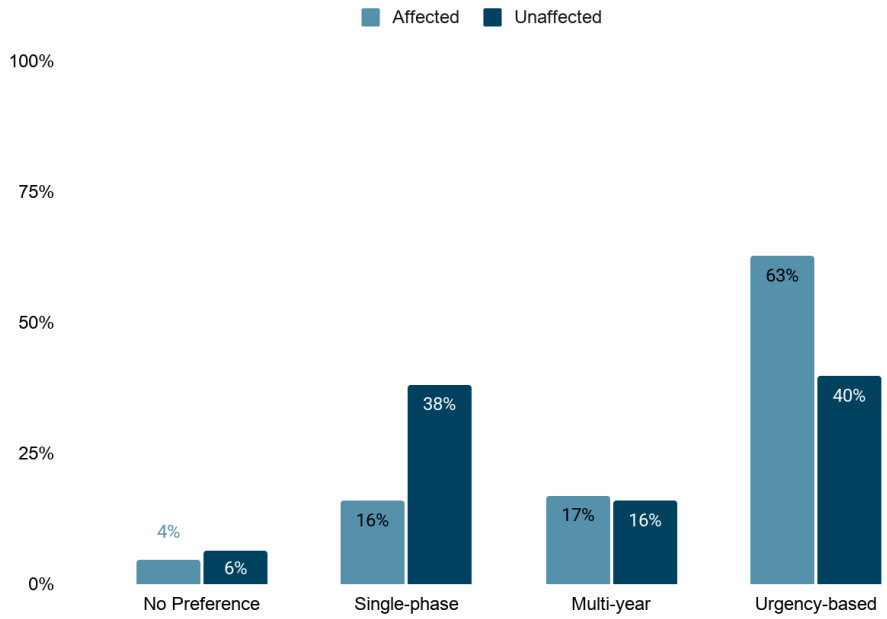
Close-Ended Response Analysis

Below, we present the results for close-ended questions regarding Rightsizing preferences, disaggregated by whether or not a respondent is directly affected by the proposed scenarios or not. Affected schools include any building facing a closure, a boundary change, or a programming change.

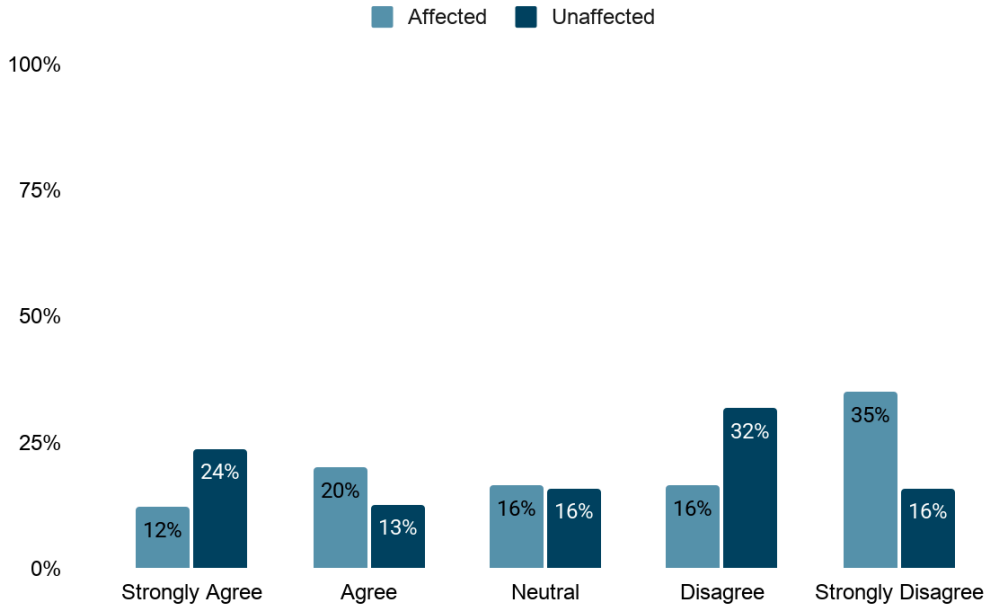
Resolution 7307 says that neighborhood schools are the foundation of the system when balancing access to choice programs. How well do the proposed scenarios balance those two needs?



Rightsizing involves a trade-off between how large changes are and how often they occur. Which approach best aligns with your priorities?



How much do you agree with this statement? "I am willing to accept a larger near-term adjustment (e.g., boundary change or closure) if it guarantees my school will not face further rightsizing for at least 5 years."



Open-Ended Response Analysis:
The survey asked the following open-ended questions:

- What specific support (e.g., transportation to school, students staying with their classmates) would you need if school changes occur all at once instead of over several years?
- What specific resources or help should the district provide to support schools affected by rightsizing?
- Our goal is to create a model that is fair and equitable to all communities. Did we miss any important equity issues, community history, or student needs in creating these models? If yes, please tell us what we missed and how we can address it.
- What is one thing you would like us to know about your school community?

Below, we present emerging findings from all open-ended questions across four themes: supports and resources, equity analysis, emerging themes, and emerging questions. We further disaggregate these responses by regional cluster.

Across all regions, families say that reliable transportation to and from school and keeping friend groups together are essential supports for students experiencing change. Many respondents stressed that the district must provide free transportation, clear bus routes, and safe walking paths across busy roads. Parents also strongly agree that students should move together in whole classrooms or grade-level cohorts so they do not lose their primary social support network. Additionally, community members frequently asked PPS to retain familiar teachers and hire more mental health counselors, social workers, and transition aides to help students adapt to new environments.

Families also cautioned the district not to repeat past mistakes that harmed vulnerable groups. Responses repeatedly highlighted that low-income students, families of color, English language learners, and Special Education (SPED) students face the highest risk during school closures. Community members also pointed out physical inequalities between buildings, stating that moving students into older facilities without working heating, air conditioning, or safe play areas creates an unfair learning environment.

Finally, a major theme across all open-ended feedback is a deep lack of trust in district leadership and data. About one in five respondents questioned whether enrollment projections are accurate. Families expressed frustration with the decision-making timeline and requested a clear multi-year roadmap rather than repeated minor adjustments every few years. Concerns about class size, building capacity, and losing tight-knit school cultures were also widespread.

North Region
Feedback from the North region (Jefferson and Roosevelt cluster) strongly focuses on racial equity, historical community impact, and Dual Language Immersion programs. Nearly a third of comments (32%) urged the district to protect Spanish Dual Language Immersion programs from being split up or shut down. Community members cited North Portland's history of gentrification, displacement, and past school closures, warning the district not to place an unfair burden on Black, Brown, and low-income families. Responses also stressed the need to preserve Title I wraparound services, free meal programs, and culturally responsive staff who reflect the student body.

Northeast Region
In the Northeast region (Grant and McDaniel cluster), families talked about teacher retention and keeping academic tracks intact. Almost a third of respondents urged the district to keep experienced

teachers and support staff in place rather than making budget cuts or frequent staff reassignments. Parents also expressed strong concern about Dual Language Immersion pathways so students do not drop out mid-way through their education. Finally, responses highlighted the need to rebalance boundaries between overcrowded facilities and under-enrolled neighboring schools without breaking apart cohesive neighborhood communities.

Southeast Region

In the Southeast region (Cleveland and Franklin cluster), community feedback centers heavily on middle school transitions, feeder patterns, and student traffic safety. Over a quarter of comments from this region specifically focused on the shift between K-8 schools and standalone middle schools. Parents emphasized that younger students will need dedicated yellow bus service and crossing guards if forced to cross busy roads like Powell, 82nd, and Division Streets. Keeping student cohorts and friend groups together was another top priority, as parents worry that splitting kids up across different schools will hurt their social and emotional well-being.

West Region

In the West region (Ida B. Wells and Lincoln cluster), community concerns centered on aging school buildings and geographic barriers. Almost a third of families discussed facility conditions, like lack of air conditioning, seismic safety concerns, and of space in receiving schools. Because Westside neighborhoods feature steep hills, winding roads, and very few sidewalks, parents stressed that walking to school is unsafe and that district-provided busing will be necessary. Families in this cluster also expressed the highest level of distrust toward district enrollment figures, demanding raw data and financial transparency before any closures occur.

Emerging Questions

Community members brought forth many questions about the proposed scenarios. Common questions themes include:

- How will students travel safely to new schools, and will free busing be provided?
- What will happen to specialized programs like Dual Language Immersion (DLI)?
- How will the district guarantee that friend groups and student cohorts stay together?
- Are receiving school buildings large enough and in good condition to handle more students?
- Why is the district closing neighborhood schools instead of cutting administrative spending?
- How can families trust the district's enrollment numbers?
- What will happen to closed buildings?

Last Week in Community Engagement

This past week, PPS hosted five community engagement events to learn more about how specific communities were affected by the proposed rightsizing scenarios. Follow the links below to view the summaries of each engagement session.

- The Village Table (October 14)
- Community Voice: Special Education Families (October 15)
- Board of Education Community Connection (October 17)
- School Impact: Northeast Region (Oct 17)
- Latino/a/e Community Conversation (October 19)

Appendix A:

Count of Responses By School to Date. ***Note****: Some respondents represent multiple school communities*

School Name	**Total Respondents**
Abernethy E.S.	17
ACCESS K-8	27
Ainsworth E.S.	10
Alameda E.S.	26
Alliance	10
Arleta E.S.	11
Astor K-8	16
Atkinson E.S.	39
Beach E.S.	22
Beaumont M.S.	34
Benson Polytechnic H.S.	23
Beverly Cleary K-8	50
Boise-Eliot/Humboldt E.S.	10
Brentwood M.S.	11
Bridger Creative Science School	22
Bridlemile E.S.	22
Buckman E.S.	21
Capitol Hill E.S.	12
Cesar Chavez K-8	10
Chapman E.S.	6
Chief Joseph E.S.	11
Clark E.S.	8

Cleveland H.S.	127
Creston E.S.	37
DaVinci Arts M.S.	23
Dr Martin Luther King Jr E.S.	12
Duniway E.S.	112
Faubion PK-8	16
Forest Park E.S.	10
Franklin H.S.	43
George M.S.	23
Glencoe E.S.	12
Grant H.S.	75
Grout E.S.	15
Harriet Tubman M.S.	25
Harrison Park M.S.	20
Hayhurst E.S.	14
Hosford M.S.	31
Ida B Wells-Barnett H.S.	46
Irvington E.S.	48
Jackson M.S.	58
James John E.S.	106
Jefferson H.S.	20
Kellogg M.S.	17
Kelly E.S.	4
Laurelhurst K-8	46
Lent E.S.	3
Leodis V McDaniel H.S.	24

Lewis E.S.	65
Lincoln H.S.	37
Llewellyn E.S.	108
Maplewood E.S.	102
Markham E.S.	18
Marysville E.S.	21
Metropolitan Learning Center	17
Mt Tabor M.S.	15
Ockley Green M.S.	23
Odyssey Program K-8	13
Peninsula E.S.	40
Pioneer	8
Reconnection Center	3
Richmond E.S.	11
Rieke E.S.	11
Rigler E.S.	19
Robert Gray M.S.	16
Roosevelt H.S.	34
Rosa Parks E.S.	6
Rose City Park E.S.	62
Roseway Heights M.S.	25
Sabin E.S.	37
Scott E.S.	26
Sellwood M.S.	253
Sitton E.S.	51
Skyline K-8	20

Stephenson E.S.	123
Sunnyside Environmental K-8	94
Sunrise E.S.	4
Vernon K-8	33
Vestal E.S.	5
West Sylvan M.S.	19
Whitman E.S.	11
Winterhaven K-8	15
Woodlawn E.S.	9
Woodmere E.S.	13
Woodstock E.S.	35
Grand Total	**2787**

Appendix B:

Village Table (October 14) Summary

Meeting Purpose

This meeting of the Village Table was a place for members to learn more about why PPS developed the Rightsizing scenarios and how the proposed changes are intended to support well-resourced schools and equitable learning opportunities for students. Village Table members also learned more about how the proposed scenarios could impact regions and school communities, and how to communicate these changes accurately and thoughtfully with families.

Number of Participants: 82

Community Insights (What Resonated?)

Theme 1: "Well Resourced Schools" vs. the Loss of Resources	Village Table representatives shared that recent cuts have already stripped schools of paras, IB programs, music, and specialists. Some members shared that this reality helps them understand that school consolidations must be done, but many worry that larger schools without guaranteed staffing will mean more students, lost community partner spaces (SUN, RESJ, Childcare), and strains on other resources (auditoriums, playgrounds, cafeterias, etc.) without an increase in instructional quality. Village Table members want to see plans for how these considerations are going to be addressed before a decision is made. Additionally, some community members shared that some slated changes seem positive; for example, parents of soon-to-be 6th graders appreciate the opportunity to transition from a K-8 to a traditional middle school in order to access electives.
Theme 2: Protect Vulnerable Learners	Village Table representatives worried that big transitions will affect Special Education students, neurodivergent learners, and those in self-contained/focus classrooms. Moving students with high sensory or mobility needs into buildings without clear plans for physical accessibility (elevators/ADA), classroom capacity, elopement safety, or transition support threatens students' well-being.
Theme 3: Concerns about DLI	Some representatives voiced concern that centralizing Dual Language Immersion programs will isolate students and unintentionally segregate schools. Families want to understand why dual language immersion campus models are being recommended, and how students and families will be affected. Additionally, some community members want to see detailed safety plans to protect families from ICE and other threats to community safety when making longer commutes to school.
Theme 4: More Data and More Detail	Village Table members want to know more about how scenarios were built, what data was used, and what the plan is overall. Representatives feel information is withheld or delivered to the media

	before families, leaving them to act as unpaid "ambassadors" for incomplete plans without seeing their feedback reflected back. Overall, Village Table members want more information.
Theme 5: Closure vs. Consolidation	Especially in the North region, Village Table members were curious about how proposed school closures could be mergers instead of closures. Members want to know how school culture and staff will live on in new buildings, and how teachers across consolidations will be affected.

Opportunities

- District leaders have the opportunity to shift the narrative and administrative process from closing schools to merging two schools. By intentionally integrating school cultures, staff, traditions, and names, PPS can honor community history and lessen transition trauma.
- Village Table Members encourage PPS staff to build a unified, public data dashboard containing audited facility costs, enrollment projection methodologies, DLI metrics, and staffing models.
- The district can pioneer robust transition protocols specifically tailored for SPED, neurodivergent, and DLI students—including transition days, physical facility retrofits, and dedicated spaces for community partners (SUN, RESJ, Childcare).
- Village Table members want this space to be used for two-way communication - instead of just making comments and identifying questions, members want meetings to be a space where district representatives can provide transparent answers.

Questions for District Leadership

- How will staffing allocations, seniority, and reassignments operate under existing PAT contracts during closures vs. mergers, and on what exact timeline will staff and families see school-level staffing plans?
- What specific instructional and operational metrics define a "well-resourced school," and how will PPS guarantee that increased school size translates into better teaching and support rather than just higher student density and lost elective/para support?
- How has the district accounted for physical accessibility (elevators/ADA), classroom capacity, sensory needs, and elopement/safety protections for SPED focus classroom students being moved to receiving schools?
- How will PPS mitigate the loss of Title I funding at specific schools (e.g., Markham, Brentwood), prevent DLI consolidation from creating racial isolation?
- How was the decision made to consolidate DLI programs into campuses? And if this proposal is moved forward, what safety plans will be in place to protect vulnerable students and families?
- If rightsizing moves forward, there will be schools remaining that have enrollment below the identified thresholds due to geographic isolation and other factors. Will they be left vulnerable for future rightsizing? How will these buildings be served/will they also be well-resourced?

Appendix C:

Community Voice: Disability Voices (October 15) Summary

Location: Kellogg Middle School
Number of community members in attendance: 44

What We Heard

Some families that attended this session expressed that K-8 schools can offer a supportive environment for neurodivergent students. These parents shared that K-8s can help keep special education students in public schools, even if district data shows similar academic results between K-8 and 6-8 models overall. While some acknowledge that K-8 teachers handle heavy workloads, parents value the strong community culture and effective special education support these schools provide.

Parents involved in the Disability Voices community want clear information about future staffing levels, funding, and class sizes. Many disagree with the idea that larger schools are better, noting that crowded classrooms overstimulate neurodivergent children. Families are asking for specific student-to-teacher ratios, and want information about staffing numbers right away. Without concrete details on support staff, parents find it difficult to trust the proposed changes.

Families worry that building plans focus heavily on square footage and building age rather than actual accessibility and the physical needs of the communities served by a building. They noted that buildings like Creston feature specialized equipment, including acoustic carpeting and emergency deaf reader boards. Parents want to know if receiving schools will match these essential physical accommodations. Additionally, parents are concerned that moving the Columbia Regional Deaf and Hard of Hearing program away from Creston will disrupt a closely integrated community. Moving the program to a new location would require retraining new staff because all staff in the building support the students in this program, not just the program-specific educators.

Questions Raised

- How are students and staff being engaged and included in this process?
- Will receiving school buildings have the same physical accommodations and trained staff?
- What will staffing levels, special education support, and class sizes actually look like?

Appendix D:

Board of Education Community Connection (October 17) Summary

Location: McDaniel High School
Number of Attendees: 102

What We Heard

In this Community Connection, many attendees acknowledged that the district is facing a structural deficit and declining enrollment, and agreed that systemic changes are necessary. However, many attendees expressed that the timeline is a barrier to feeling ready for a decision. Participants want more transparency in how the proposed scenarios came to be and expressed the desire to evaluate multiple alternatives.

Some families expressed concern about how Special Education and neurodivergent students are included in the proposed scenarios. Some expressed that the needs of students receiving special education services were “treated as an afterthought.” Moving high-needs students into larger schools may threaten their physical and emotional stability. Additionally, some participants expressed concern that the proposed shifts to Dual Language Immersion (DLI) programs create unfair barriers for immigrant families and students of color. Relocating or splitting DLI programs forces working parents to choose between cultural education and local neighborhood access.

Still others expressed concern regarding commuting to school. Redrawing boundaries sometimes disrupts walkability and may require multiple bus transfers that strain parents without personal transportation. Additionally, merging campuses threatens to strip Title 1 funding from sites, while leaving vacant buildings in neighborhood hubs. Instead of rushing to close schools by December, some community members want the district to explore state rainy-day funds and build a clearer implementation model that proves it will not harm the students who need support the most.

Questions Raised

- What specific data and facility trade-offs justify closing or moving individual schools?
- How will the district protect Special Education (SPED) students from overcrowding and loss of services?
- How will the district address the commuter burdens placed on working families?
- Are there examples of other districts where school closures at this scale improved student outcomes?
- How will the district prevent vulnerable schools from losing Title 1 funding when boundaries change?

Appendix E:

School Impact: Northeast Region (Oct 17) Summary

Coming soon!

Appendix F:
Latino/a/e Community Conversation (October 19) Summary

Location: Hosford Middle School & Virtual
Number of Attendees: 20 in personal 17 virtual

What We Heard

Many of the Latino/a/e community members in attendance opposed PPS's proposed school closures and Dual Language Immersion (DLI) consolidations. Speakers stressed that moving neighborhood DLI programs into consolidated single-site schools may segregate learning environments, expose undocumented families to immigration enforcement, and place heavy commute burdens on working parents.

Participants want more information about why this decision was made. Some asked for research and evidence that whole-school DLI models are as effective or better for students' academic and social development than having co-located programs.

Families were also concerned that there has not been enough engagement with the Latino/a/e community broadly, wanting more opportunities to respond and be engaged about changes, especially those that affect the Spanish-language DLI program.

Questions Raised

- Is there research or data that shows that whole-school Dual Language Immersion programs have equal or better academic or social outcomes than co-located neighborhood programs?
- What transportation and safety plans exist to address bus rides, hazardous driving corridors, and winter travel?
- What protective measures will PPS implement to ensure undocumented parents and extended family members are not exposed to ICE during school drop-offs and pick-ups?
- Will consolidating Dual Language Immersion programs reduce the overall number of seats available for native Spanish speakers, and what will the ratio of native speakers to neighborhood students be at receiving schools?
- Why are program changes happening now instead of making gradual adjustments?